



VAUGHAN WILLIAMS AND HOLST

This photograph by composer William Gillies Whittaker shows Gustav Holst and Vaughan Williams—lifelong friends—walking in the Malvern Hills in 1921.

A breakthrough

The breakthrough came in 1910, when Vaughan Williams, now already in his late thirties, conducted the first performances of two very different masterworks. The first of these was *Fantasia on a Theme by Thomas Tallis*, which premiered in Gloucester Cathedral during the Three Choirs Festival. It is a single, 20-minute movement written for an orchestra of string instruments only—a solo quartet, a large main ensemble, and a distantly deployed smaller ensemble. The tune is fragmented, varied, freely extended in different directions, and then eventually reassembled, all in a wholly new sound-world whose outward calm conveys great inward power.